

Filipinism:
A Model For Sustainable Architecture In Tropical Climates

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Filipinism: A Model For Sustainable Architecture In Tropical Climates

Walking into a newly built, Mediterranean-inspired "dream home" in the provinces often comes with an unpleasant awakening: despite the beautiful facade, the interior becomes unbearably hot in the afternoon, requiring multiple air-conditioning units running at full blast just to stay comfortable. This common experience points to a much larger crisis in Philippine architecture. In a country defined by persistent humidity, designs frequently prioritize foreign aesthetics, French or Swiss styles, for instance — over actual thermal comfort. In Metro Manila, glass buildings trap heat during the summer months, and mechanical cooling systems work overtime to compensate for what the facade fails to block. The resulting glare also worsens the urban heat island effect, making the streets below even hotter. While occupants inside remain comfortable, this comes at a steep cost in electricity. This situation reveals a recurring problem in Philippine architecture: for decades, the profession has borrowed design styles from colder climates and then spent enormous resources making them liveable in the tropics. It is a contradiction that continues to shape city skylines with energy-intensive towers.

This pattern is often described as a colonial hangover, the habit of following Western design standards without question (Franz Sorilla IV, 2022). After centuries of Spanish and American influence, the Philippines developed a particular view of materials where concrete, steel, and glass came to represent progress and modernity, while local materials like bamboo, rattan, and nipa were dismissed as temporary or inferior. Even the *bahay na bato*, which successfully combined Spanish planning with tropical sensibility, was eventually set aside in favor of mainstream international styles. As a result, many modern buildings look impressive from the outside but perform poorly in the local climate.

The philosophy of Filipinism was developed to address these shortcomings. Promoted by Architect Francisco Mañosa and his son Architect Gelo Mañosa, the movement is not simply about looking to the past. Rather, it argues that local building traditions carry deep architectural knowledge. The traditional *bahay kubo*, for example, is not merely a simple hut, it is a sophisticated climate management system that Filipino builders refined over generations, without the need for modern machinery.

The design of the *bahay kubo* reflects a thorough understanding of the environment. The *silong*, or raised floor, protects the home from dampness and flooding while allowing air to circulate underneath. The steep roof efficiently drains heavy rainfall and creates high ceilings where hot air can rise and escape. Slatted floors and *sawali* walls further encourage natural ventilation, turning even a light breeze into a cooling draft (Tameta, 2025).

Western building styles, by contrast, are often poorly suited to this region. Structures designed for cold climates prioritize sealing heat inside through thick walls and small windows, the opposite of what is needed in a hot and humid environment. In the Philippines, the design priority should be heat rejection and continuous air circulation. Both colonial-era concrete houses and contemporary glass towers tend to treat the building envelope as a solid barrier against nature rather than a breathable filter.

This mismatch leads to heavy dependence on air conditioning, which can account for up to 60% of a building's total energy consumption. According to the Department of Energy (2024), demand from buildings remained high, placing significant strain on the power grid and contributing to summer blackouts. The *bahay kubo*, in contrast, demonstrates passive design that requires no electricity for cooling. Modern architects are now applying these traditional principles at a larger scale, through deep roof overhangs, strategic ventilation, and the use of natural materials such as bamboo, rattan, and wood. These materials were not inferior; they were simply undervalued due to social perception rather than actual performance (Lopez, 2025).

Technical research supports the strength of local materials. Engineered bamboo, for instance, can achieve tensile strength comparable to steel while carrying a significantly lower carbon footprint. Studies have also shown that new bamboo panels can be used for structural walls (Xiao et al., 2014). Cogon grass offers excellent insulation and helps muffle the sound of heavy rain. These materials now have scientific backing; in the past, they simply lacked formal recognition from building codes and academic institutions that tended to favor imported alternatives.

Filipinism maintains that genuine sustainability must be locally grounded, rooted in the specific conditions of the archipelago, with its heavy rainfall and rich biodiversity. A building that relies on efficient machinery but uses materials shipped from across the world is not truly sustainable, as the carbon cost of transport remains too high. In this context, a sustainable building draws from local resources and responds directly to the local climate and culture.

Proponents of this movement frame it as a new kind of modernism. To be modern in the Philippines means being climate-smart and honest about materials, designing spaces that do not require constant air conditioning just to be habitable. While this approach demands more thoughtfulness than simply copying foreign trends, it produces buildings that genuinely belong in their environment.

Philippine architecture stands at an exciting crossroads. The profession now has both the tools and the science to build with bamboo and incorporate natural ventilation into contemporary structures. The assumption that Western styles are inherently superior was always a residual colonial habit. Moving past

it does not mean rejecting progress, it simply requires the confidence to treat the Philippines as the primary source of design inspiration.

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